



CRAIG HUDSON FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

NFC CHAMPIONSHIP GAME

GETTING THEIR SWAGGER BACK

The Commanders' rise has purged decades of gloom for their long-suffering fans

BY RICK MAESE AND JOE HEIM

For years, people mostly ignored Chris Bryant and his pickup truck. But these days, when they spot it zipping along Virginia roads — decked out in burgundy and gold and oversized images of Washington Commanders past and present — they honk or stop him for selfies.

"It's kind of a dream," Bryant says. "I don't want this season to end."

Frank Emmet was 7 when he attended his first game at Griffith Stadium in Northwest D.C. That was 1940, just three years after the team moved to the District. He's 91 now.

"I don't think I ever gave up," he says about the team's long slide. "I was just hoping. Hoping and hoping and hoping."

For Allison Bradley of Gainesville, a season ticket holder since 2021, the games have been a thrilling way over the years to connect with her two preteen sons who are obsessed with the team. But as the team kept winning this season, she noticed something else.

"For them, it's exciting to have a winning football team," says Bradley, 43. "... On my end, it's cool to see how it brings a community together with all the other stuff that's happening in the world."

SEE COMMANDERS ON A20



JOHN MCDONNELL FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

For Washington fans, wearing the team's gear became an albatross and their loyalty was tested by years of losing and controversies. They celebrated when Josh Harris, above, led a group that bought the team from Daniel Snyder in 2023. Now they are one win from celebrating a Super Bowl trip.

Basketball guys: Daniels is a perfect point guard for the Commanders. **D1**

A way with words: Quinn inspires his team anywhere, anytime. **D1**

Path to the top: A page of Post pages from a memorable season. **D10**



Fan fare: Get a poster-quality copy and more items at wapo.st/commanders.

In second season since sale to Harris, NFL again has a flagship franchise in D.C.

BY NICKI JHARVALA AND MARK MASKE

When the Washington Commanders take the field Sunday in Philadelphia for the NFC championship game, the moment will represent not only a radical transformation for the franchise but also relieved satisfaction for the NFL, the country's most popular and profitable sports league.

Professional sports franchises are unique among multibillion-dollar businesses. They have extravagantly compensated employees and deep emotional connections with their customers. They can lead otherwise shrewd businessmen to make decisions they wouldn't consider in other investments and competitors to cheer their on-field rivals' financial good health.

That has been on display before, during and since a group headed by private equity investor Josh Harris purchased the Commanders from Daniel Snyder for \$6.05 billion in July 2023. Harris's group, which includes other prominent investors with roots in the D.C. area and long-standing affection for the team, installed new leadership that made over a franchise that is now a victory from the Super Bowl. Before that could happen, Harris

SEE HARRIS ON A28

Week 1: Trump comes out swinging

'FLOOD THE ZONE' TACTIC HAS WASHINGTON DIZZY

All part of a well-oiled plan to begin second term with a bang

BY ISAAC ARNSDORF AND CLARA ENCE MORSE

President Donald Trump spent his first week back in office flooding the zone. He pardoned hundreds of supporters who assaulted police on Jan. 6, 2021, revoked security clearances for critics and floated dramatic proposals such as eliminating the Federal Emergency Management Agency.

It was all part of a plan to begin with a bang, follow a detailed policy blueprint and be better organized than eight years ago.

Trump's ambitions for his first hours in office fell short in some ways, including hiring bottlenecks for key administration jobs, court challenges to executive orders that had eluded legal vetting and directives that lacked immediate effect.

Some agencies are at less than one-third strength in their "beachhead" teams, according to three people familiar with the situation who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they weren't authorized to speak publicly.

But the president was pleased with his

SEE STRATEGY ON A8

What happened on Saturday

Kristi L. Noem, President Trump's pick to lead the Department of Homeland Security, was confirmed by the Senate. **A3**

Pete Hegseth was sworn in as defense secretary following a narrow confirmation.

At least 15 Cabinet-level agencies were without inspectors general after a late-night purge by the White House.

House Speaker Mike Johnson invited the president to address a joint session of Congress on March 4. **A10**

President defends purge of government watchdogs

Trump's dismissals appear to violate federal law requiring a 30-day notice to Congress

BY DAVID NAKAMURA, LISA REIN AND MATT VISER

President Donald Trump on Saturday night defended his removal of a slew of inspectors general Friday night, as lawmakers in both parties raised concerns about the late-night purge and questioned a decision that appeared to violate federal law.

"It's a very common thing to do," Trump claimed to reporters on Air Force One traveling to Florida, in his first comments after a decision that caused alarm among government watchdogs and members of Congress.

"I don't know them," he said, even though many of those he fired were people that he appointed during his first term. "But some people thought that some were unfair or some were not doing their job. It's a very standard thing to do."

The White House removed the independent inspectors general of nearly every Cabinet-level agency in an unprecedented

SEE TRUMP ON A5

Hamas reemerges in Gaza, badly bruised but still influential

Group maintains its grip even after 15 months of war

BY GERRY SHIH, MIRIAM BERGER AND HAZEM BALOUSHA

JERUSALEM — After the ceasefire in Gaza came into effect this past week, a modicum of normalcy returned to life inside the devastated enclave. So did Hamas.

For the first time in a year, the militant group's armed wing openly paraded through the streets and held public funerals for slain fighters. On war-battered streets crowded with mule carts and dis-

placed civilians returning to what remained of their homes, Hamas-affiliated police officers in blue uniforms barked orders and directed traffic. On social media, Hamas accounts that had gone dark reactivated overnight. One account touted photos of a militant commander whom Israel claimed to have killed walking around in public, seemingly unscathed.

The scenes highlighted how after 15 months of ferocious bombardment and military raids, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu may have decimated Hamas's fighting capabilities and leveled much of Gaza, but he has failed to

SEE HAMAS ON A19

4 female soldiers returned to Israel; 200 Palestinians freed

BY SHIRA RUBIN, VICTORIA CRAW AND BRYAN PIETSCH

TEL AVIV — Four female Israeli soldiers held hostage were released by Hamas in Gaza City and 200 Palestinian prisoners were released by Israel on Saturday, the start of a second week of a planned six-week ceasefire deal that has halted 15 months of fighting and allowed Hamas to project an image of resilience.

Hours before releasing the hostages,

the militants paraded the women, dressed in army green, in a public square in Gaza and forced them to climb a stage, smile and raise their arms for a gaggle of cameramen.

The hostages were then transferred to the Red Cross vans that would take them home to Israel. At the Israeli military facility at the border, at the hospital waiting to receive them and at viewing parties across the country, parents, siblings and friends of the women — Liri Albag, 19, Naama Levy, 20, Karina Arielev, 20, and Daniella Gilboa, 20 — wept with joy at seeing them walking on their own.

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